

1.1: Complex Numbers

1. Introduction and Definition

Imaginary unit: The imaginary unit i is defined by $i^2 = -1$, so $i = \sqrt{-1}$.

Complex number: A complex number has the form $z = a + bi$ where $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$. The set of all complex numbers is denoted $\mathbb{C}$.

Real part: $\operatorname{Re}(z) = a$

Imaginary part: $\operatorname{Im}(z) = b$ (note: this is the real number b , not bi)

Every real number is also a complex number with $\operatorname{Im}(z) = 0$. Numbers of the form bi (where $b \neq 0$ and $a = 0$) are called *purely imaginary*.

Powers of i

The powers of i cycle with period 4:

Power	i^1	i^2	i^3	i^4	i^5
Value	i	-1	$-i$	1	i

AQA Exam Tip: When simplifying expressions involving powers of i , always reduce using $i^2 = -1$. For i^n , divide n by 4 and use the remainder: remainder 0 gives 1, remainder 1 gives i , remainder 2 gives -1 , remainder 3 gives $-i$.

2. Arithmetic with Complex Numbers

Addition and Subtraction

$$(a + bi) \pm (c + di) = (a \pm c) + (b \pm d)i$$

Multiplication

Expand using FOIL, then substitute $i^2 = -1$:

$$(a + bi)(c + di) = (ac - bd) + (ad + bc)i$$

Example: Find $(3 + 2i)(1 - 4i)$.

$$(3 + 2i)(1 - 4i) = 3 - 12i + 2i - 8i^2 = 3 - 10i + 8 = 11 - 10i$$

The Complex Conjugate

Complex conjugate: If $z = a + bi$, then the conjugate is $z^* = a - bi$ (also written $\bar{z}$).

Key properties:

- $z + z^* = 2a$ (always real)
- $z \cdot z^* = a^2 + b^2 = |z|^2$ (always real and non-negative)
- $(z^*)^* = z$
- $\overline{z_1 z_2} = \overline{z_1} \overline{z_2}$
- $\overline{z_1 + z_2} = \overline{z_1} + \overline{z_2}$

Division

Multiply numerator and denominator by the conjugate of the denominator:

$$\frac{a + bi}{c + di} = \frac{(a + bi)(c - di)}{c^2 + d^2} = \frac{(ac + bd) + (bc - ad)i}{c^2 + d^2}$$

Example: Simplify $\frac{3 + 5i}{1 + 2i}$.

$$\frac{(3 + 5i)(1 - 2i)}{(1 + 2i)(1 - 2i)} = \frac{3 - 6i + 5i - 10i^2}{1 + 4} = \frac{13 - i}{5} = \frac{13}{5} - \frac{1}{5}i$$

AQA Exam Tip: Division questions often carry 3–4 marks. Show the multiplication by the conjugate explicitly — the examiner wants to see that step.

3. Modulus and Argument

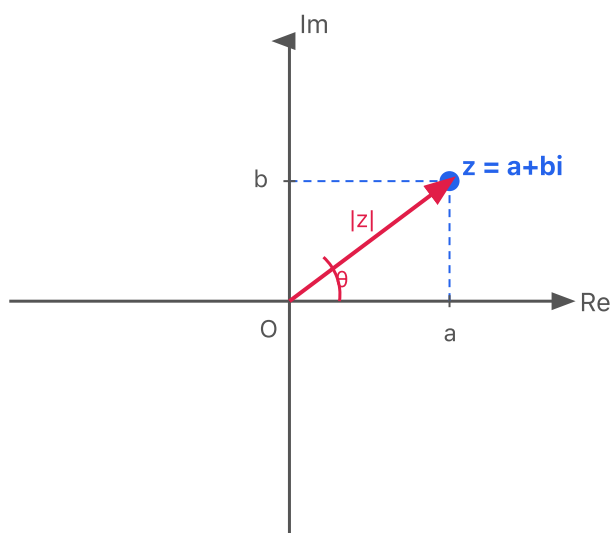
Modulus: $|z| = \sqrt{a^2 + b^2}$ — the distance of z from the origin in the Argand diagram.

Argument: $\arg(z) = \theta$ where $\tan \theta = \frac{b}{a}$ — the angle measured anticlockwise from the positive real axis.

The **principal argument** satisfies $-\pi < \arg(z) \leq \pi$.

Argand Diagram

A complex number $z = a + bi$ is represented as the point (a, b) in the complex plane.



Calculating the Argument Carefully

Quadrant	Sign of a, b	Principal argument range	Method
1st	$a > 0, b > 0$	$0 < \theta \leq \frac{\pi}{2}$	$\theta = \arctan\left(\frac{b}{a}\right)$
2nd	$a < 0, b > 0$	$\frac{\pi}{2} < \theta \leq \pi$	$\theta = \pi - \arctan\left(\frac{b}{ a }\right)$
3rd	$a < 0, b < 0$	$-\pi < \theta \leq -\frac{\pi}{2}$	$\theta = -\pi + \arctan\left(\frac{ b }{ a }\right)$
4th	$a > 0, b < 0$	$-\frac{\pi}{2} < \theta < 0$	$\theta = -\arctan\left(\frac{ b }{a}\right)$

Example: Find $|z|$ and $\arg(z)$ for $z = -1 + \sqrt{3}i$.

$$|z| = \sqrt{1 + 3} = 2$$

$$\text{Second quadrant: reference angle} = \arctan\left(\frac{\sqrt{3}}{1}\right) = \frac{\pi}{3}$$

$$\arg(z) = \pi - \frac{\pi}{3} = \frac{2\pi}{3}$$

Modulus-Argument Properties

$$|z_1 z_2| = |z_1| |z_2| \quad \arg(z_1 z_2) = \arg(z_1) + \arg(z_2)$$

$$\left| \frac{z_1}{z_2} \right| = \frac{|z_1|}{|z_2|} \quad \arg\left(\frac{z_1}{z_2}\right) = \arg(z_1) - \arg(z_2)$$

4. Modulus-Argument Form and Euler's Formula

Modulus-argument (polar) form:

$$z = r(\cos \theta + i \sin \theta) = r e^{i\theta}$$

where $r = |z|$ and $\theta = \arg(z)$.

Euler's formula: $e^{i\theta} = \cos \theta + i \sin \theta$

Example: Write $z = 1 + i$ in modulus-argument form.

$$r = \sqrt{1^2 + 1^2} = \sqrt{2}, \arg(z) = \frac{\pi}{4}$$

$$z = \sqrt{2} \left(\cos \frac{\pi}{4} + i \sin \frac{\pi}{4} \right) = \sqrt{2} e^{i\pi/4}$$

AQA Exam Tip: AQA uses both $r(\cos \theta + i \sin \theta)$ and $r e^{i\theta}$ forms. Know how to convert fluently in both directions.

5. de Moivre's Theorem

de Moivre's Theorem: For integer n ,

$$[r(\cos \theta + i \sin \theta)]^n = r^n (\cos n\theta + i \sin n\theta)$$

Equivalently: $(re^{i\theta})^n = r^n e^{in\theta}$.

Application: Trigonometric Identities

de Moivre's theorem is used to express $\cos(n\theta)$ in terms of powers of $\cos \theta$ (and $\sin \theta$).

Example: Use de Moivre's theorem to show that $\cos 3\theta = 4 \cos^3 \theta - 3 \cos \theta$.

$$(\cos \theta + i \sin \theta)^3 = \cos 3\theta + i \sin 3\theta$$

Expanding left side by binomial theorem:

$$\begin{aligned} \cos^3 \theta + 3 \cos^2 \theta (i \sin \theta) + 3 \cos \theta (i \sin \theta)^2 + (i \sin \theta)^3 \\ = \cos^3 \theta + 3i \cos^2 \theta \sin \theta - 3 \cos \theta \sin^2 \theta - i \sin^3 \theta \end{aligned}$$

$$\text{Real part: } \cos 3\theta = \cos^3 \theta - 3 \cos \theta \sin^2 \theta = \cos^3 \theta - 3 \cos \theta (1 - \cos^2 \theta) = 4 \cos^3 \theta - 3 \cos \theta \quad \checkmark$$

Expressing $\cos^n \theta$ and $\sin^n \theta$

Using $z = e^{i\theta}$:

$$\begin{aligned} z + z^{-1} &= 2 \cos \theta, & z - z^{-1} &= 2i \sin \theta \\ z^n + z^{-n} &= 2 \cos n\theta, & z^n - z^{-n} &= 2i \sin n\theta \end{aligned}$$

Example: Express $\cos^4 \theta$ in terms of multiple angles.

Let $z = e^{i\theta}$, so $2 \cos \theta = z + z^{-1}$.

$$\begin{aligned} (2 \cos \theta)^4 &= (z + z^{-1})^4 = z^4 + 4z^2 + 6 + 4z^{-2} + z^{-4} \\ &= (z^4 + z^{-4}) + 4(z^2 + z^{-2}) + 6 = 2 \cos 4\theta + 8 \cos 2\theta + 6 \end{aligned}$$

$$\text{Therefore: } \cos^4 \theta = \frac{1}{16} (2 \cos 4\theta + 8 \cos 2\theta + 6) = \frac{1}{8} \cos 4\theta + \frac{1}{2} \cos 2\theta + \frac{3}{8}$$

6. Roots of Unity and n th Roots

n th Roots of Unity

The equation $z^n = 1$ has exactly n roots in $\mathbb{C}$:

$$z_k = e^{2\pi i k/n} = \cos\left(\frac{2\pi k}{n}\right) + i \sin\left(\frac{2\pi k}{n}\right), \quad k = 0, 1, 2, \dots, n-1$$

These n roots lie equally spaced on the unit circle $|z| = 1$, separated by angles of $\frac{2\pi}{n}$.

Example: Find all cube roots of unity ($z^3 = 1$).

$$k = 0: z_0 = 1$$

$$k = 1: z_1 = \cos \frac{2\pi}{3} + i \sin \frac{2\pi}{3} = -\frac{1}{2} + \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}i$$

$$k = 2: z_2 = \cos \frac{4\pi}{3} + i \sin \frac{4\pi}{3} = -\frac{1}{2} - \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}i$$

Note: $z_1 = \omega$ and $z_2 = \omega^2 = \bar{\omega}$, where $1 + \omega + \omega^2 = 0$.

n th Roots of a Complex Number

To find the n roots of $z^n = w$ where $w = R e^{i\phi}$:

$$z_k = R^{1/n} \exp\left(i \frac{\phi + 2\pi k}{n}\right), \quad k = 0, 1, \dots, n-1$$

The roots are equally spaced on a circle of radius $R^{1/n}$ in the Argand diagram.

Example: Find the square roots of $3 + 4i$.

First: $|3 + 4i| = 5$, $\arg(3 + 4i) = \arctan\left(\frac{4}{3}\right) = \alpha$ (say).

Square roots have modulus $\sqrt{5}$ and arguments $\frac{\alpha}{2}$ and $\frac{\alpha}{2} + \pi$.

Alternatively, let $z = x + yi$: $(x + yi)^2 = 3 + 4i$

$x^2 - y^2 = 3$ and $2xy = 4$, so $y = 2/x$.

$x^2 - 4/x^2 = 3 \Rightarrow x^4 - 3x^2 - 4 = 0 \Rightarrow (x^2 - 4)(x^2 + 1) = 0$

$x = \pm 2$, giving $z = 2 + i$ or $z = -2 - i$.

AQA Exam Tip: AQA commonly asks for n th roots on the Argand diagram. The roots always form a regular polygon on the circle $|z| = R^{1/n}$. Mark angles clearly and state each root in both exact polar and Cartesian forms where possible.

7. Loci in the Argand Diagram

Circle: $|z - a| = r$

The set of all z at distance r from the fixed point a . This is a circle centre a , radius r .

Perpendicular Bisector: $|z - a| = |z - b|$

The set of all z equidistant from a and b . This is the perpendicular bisector of the line segment from a to b .

Half-line: $\arg(z - a) = \theta$

The set of all z such that the direction from a to z makes angle θ with the positive real axis. This is a half-line (ray) starting at a (but not including a) in the direction θ .

Example: Find the Cartesian equation of the locus $|z - 3 - 4i| = |z + 1|$.

Let $z = x + iy$. Then:

$$|z - (3 + 4i)| = |(x - 3) + (y - 4)i| = \sqrt{(x - 3)^2 + (y - 4)^2}$$

$$|z + 1| = |(x + 1) + yi| = \sqrt{(x + 1)^2 + y^2}$$

Setting equal and squaring:

$$(x - 3)^2 + (y - 4)^2 = (x + 1)^2 + y^2$$

$$x^2 - 6x + 9 + y^2 - 8y + 16 = x^2 + 2x + 1 + y^2$$

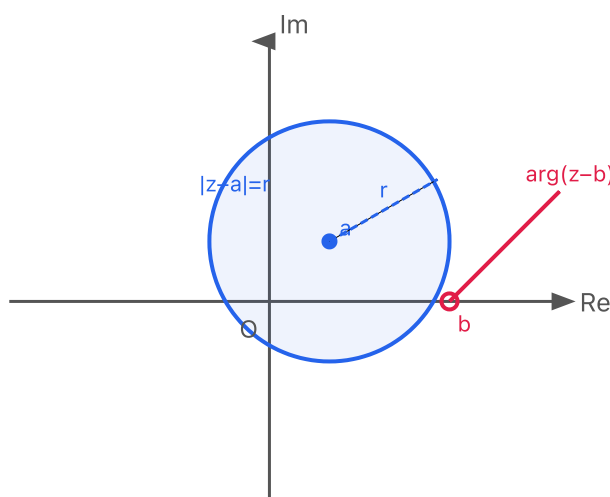
$$-6x - 8y + 25 = 2x + 1$$

$$8x + 8y = 24, \text{ so } x + y = 3.$$

Example: Describe the locus $\arg(z - 2) = \frac{\pi}{3}$.

This is a half-line starting at $z = 2$ (i.e. the point $(2, 0)$ on the Argand diagram), not including the point itself, making an angle of $\frac{\pi}{3}$ with the positive real direction.

In Cartesian terms: $\frac{y}{x - 2} = \tan \frac{\pi}{3} = \sqrt{3}$, so $y = \sqrt{3}(x - 2)$ for $x > 2$.



AQA Exam Tip: For locus questions, always state the type of locus (circle/perpendicular bisector/half-line), its key features (centre and radius, or the two fixed points, or the starting point and angle). AQA mark schemes award marks for correct description AND Cartesian equation.

8. Conjugate Root Theorem and Polynomial Equations

Conjugate Root Theorem: If the coefficients of a polynomial are all real, then complex roots occur in conjugate pairs. That is, if $\alpha = p + qi$ ($q \neq 0$) is a root, then $\alpha^* = p - qi$ is also a root.

Solving Cubics and Quartics

Strategy for cubics: Given one complex root α , write down α^* immediately. Form the real quadratic $(z - \alpha)(z - \alpha^*) = z^2 - 2pz + (p^2 + q^2)$. Divide the cubic by this quadratic to find the third (real) root.

Example: Given $2 + 3i$ is a root of $z^3 - 6z^2 + 21z - 26 = 0$, find all roots.

Conjugate pair: $2 + 3i$ and $2 - 3i$.

Quadratic factor: $(z - (2 + 3i))(z - (2 - 3i)) = (z - 2)^2 + 9 = z^2 - 4z + 13$

Divide: $z^3 - 6z^2 + 21z - 26 = (z^2 - 4z + 13)(z - 2)$

Third root: $z = 2$. All roots: $2 + 3i$, $2 - 3i$, 2 .

Example (Quartic): $z^4 + 2z^3 + 6z^2 - 10z + 33 = 0$ has a root $z = 1 + i\sqrt{2}$. Find all roots.

Conjugate: $1 - i\sqrt{2}$.

Quadratic: $(z - 1 - i\sqrt{2})(z - 1 + i\sqrt{2}) = (z - 1)^2 + 2 = z^2 - 2z + 3$

Let $(z^2 - 2z + 3)(z^2 + az + b) = z^4 + (a - 2)z^3 + (b - 2a + 3)z^2 + (3a - 2b)z + 3b$.

Comparing: $a - 2 = 2 \Rightarrow a = 4$; $b - 8 + 3 = 6 \Rightarrow b = 11$. Check: $3a - 2b = 12 - 22 = -10 \checkmark$ and $3b = 33 \checkmark$.

So $z^4 + 2z^3 + 6z^2 - 10z + 33 = (z^2 - 2z + 3)(z^2 + 4z + 11)$.

$z^2 + 4z + 11 = 0 \Rightarrow z = -2 \pm i\sqrt{7}$. All roots: $1 \pm i\sqrt{2}$, $-2 \pm i\sqrt{7}$.

AQA Exam Tip: When performing polynomial long division in exam conditions, write out each step carefully. A common AQA question is: "Given that $p + qi$ is a root, find all the other roots and hence write the polynomial as a product of linear and quadratic factors over $\mathbb{R}$."

9. Summary of Key Results

Property	Formula / Statement
Definition of i	$i^2 = -1$
Conjugate	$z^* = a - bi$ if $z = a + bi$
Modulus	$ z = \sqrt{a^2 + b^2}$
Modulus of product	$ z_1 z_2 = z_1 z_2 $
Argument of product	$\arg(z_1 z_2) = \arg z_1 + \arg z_2$
Modulus-argument form	$z = r(\cos \theta + i \sin \theta) = re^{i\theta}$
Euler's formula	$e^{i\theta} = \cos \theta + i \sin \theta$
de Moivre's theorem	$(re^{i\theta})^n = r^n e^{in\theta}$
n th roots of unity	$z_k = e^{2\pi i k/n}, k = 0, \dots, n-1$
Conjugate root theorem	Real-coefficient polynomials: complex roots in conjugate pairs
Circle locus	$ z - a = r$: circle, centre a , radius r
Perp bisector locus	$ z - a = z - b $: perpendicular bisector of ab
Half-line locus	$\arg(z - a) = \theta$: half-line from a at angle θ

10. Practice Checklist

- Can you perform all four arithmetic operations on complex numbers in $a + bi$ form?
- Can you convert between Cartesian and modulus-argument (polar/exponential) forms?
- Can you apply de Moivre's theorem to find powers and roots?
- Can you use de Moivre's theorem to derive multiple-angle trigonometric identities?
- Can you find all n roots of $z^n = w$ and represent them on an Argand diagram?
- Can you sketch and find Cartesian equations for circle, perpendicular bisector, and half-line loci?

- Given one complex root of a polynomial with real coefficients, can you find all other roots?

De Moivre's Theorem — Applications

De Moivre's theorem states: $(\cos \theta + i \sin \theta)^n = \cos n\theta + i \sin n\theta$ for all integers n . This allows us to express trigonometric functions of multiple angles in terms of powers of single-angle functions.

Deriving $\cos 3\theta = 4 \cos^3 \theta - 3 \cos \theta$

Method: Expand $(\cos \theta + i \sin \theta)^3$ by the binomial theorem, then apply De Moivre.

$$(\cos \theta + i \sin \theta)^3 = \cos^3 \theta + 3i \cos^2 \theta \sin \theta - 3 \cos \theta \sin^2 \theta - i \sin^3 \theta$$

By De Moivre: $(\cos \theta + i \sin \theta)^3 = \cos 3\theta + i \sin 3\theta$. Equating real parts:

$$\cos 3\theta = \cos^3 \theta - 3 \cos \theta \sin^2 \theta = \cos^3 \theta - 3 \cos \theta (1 - \cos^2 \theta)$$

$$\boxed{\cos 3\theta = 4 \cos^3 \theta - 3 \cos \theta}$$

Equating imaginary parts gives: $\sin 3\theta = 3 \sin \theta - 4 \sin^3 \theta$.

Expressing powers in terms of multiple angles

Using $z = e^{i\theta}$: $z + z^{-1} = 2 \cos \theta$ and $z - z^{-1} = 2i \sin \theta$. Therefore:

- $(2 \cos \theta)^n = (z + z^{-1})^n$ — expand with binomial theorem, then regroup pairs
- $(2i \sin \theta)^n = (z - z^{-1})^n$ — similarly

Example: $\cos^4 \theta = \frac{1}{8}(\cos 4\theta + 4 \cos 2\theta + 3)$. $(2 \cos \theta)^4 = (z + z^{-1})^4 = z^4 + 4z^2 + 6 + 4z^{-2} + z^{-4} = 2 \cos 4\theta + 8 \cos 2\theta + 6$ So $\cos^4 \theta = \frac{1}{16}(2 \cos 4\theta + 8 \cos 2\theta + 6) = \frac{1}{8}(\cos 4\theta + 4 \cos 2\theta + 3)$. ✓

n th Roots of Complex Numbers

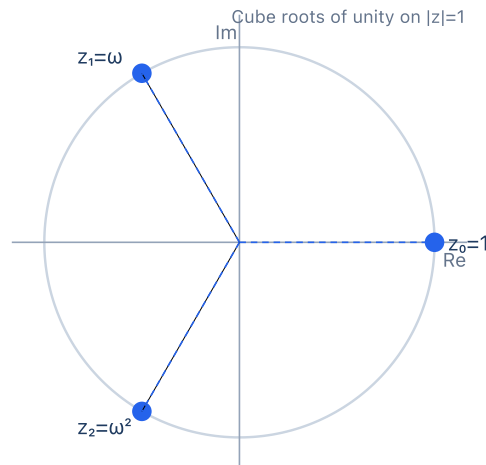
The n distinct n th roots of $w = re^{i\alpha}$ are:

$$z_k = r^{1/n} \exp\left(i \frac{\alpha + 2\pi k}{n}\right), \quad k = 0, 1, \dots, n-1$$

These lie equally spaced on a circle of radius $r^{1/n}$ centred at the origin.

Cube roots of unity

The three cube roots of $1 = e^{i \cdot 0}$ are $1, \omega, \omega^2$ where $\omega = e^{2\pi i/3}$.



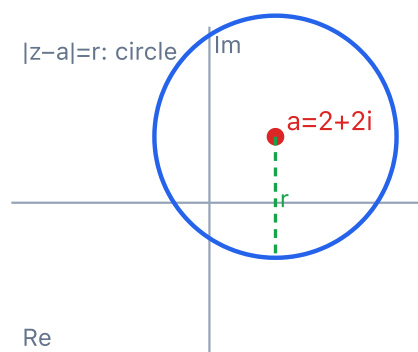
Key properties: $1 + \omega + \omega^2 = 0$ and $\omega^3 = 1$. More generally, the sum of all n th roots of unity equals zero for $n \geq 2$.

Loci in the Argand Diagram

Three fundamental types of locus appear in AQA Further Maths:

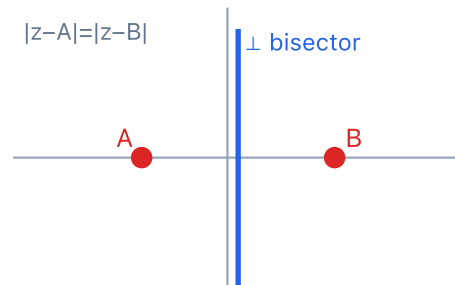
1. Circle: $|z - a| = r$

The set of points at distance r from the fixed point $a = p + qi$. In Cartesian form: $(x - p)^2 + (y - q)^2 = r^2$.



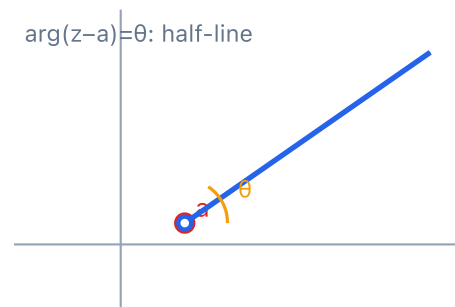
2. Perpendicular bisector: $|z - a| = |z - b|$

The set of points equidistant from a and b . This is the perpendicular bisector of the line segment AB .



3. Half-line: $\arg(z - a) = \theta$

The ray starting at a (excluded) at angle θ to the positive real direction.



Key technique: For loci of the form $|z - a| = k|z - b|$, square both sides and expand to get a circle equation. For $\arg\left(\frac{z-a}{z-b}\right) = \theta$, this typically gives an arc of a circle.

Complex Transformations $w = f(z)$

A complex transformation maps a set of points in the z -plane to a set of points in the w -plane.

$w = iz$ — Rotation

Multiplying by $i = e^{i\pi/2}$ rotates every point by $\frac{\pi}{2}$ anticlockwise about the origin. The image of the line $\operatorname{Re}(z) = 1$ (i.e. $x = 1$) under $w = iz$: set $z = 1 + iy$, then $w = i(1 + iy) = -y + i$, so $\operatorname{Re}(w) = -y$, $\operatorname{Im}(w) = 1$ — this is the line $\operatorname{Im}(w) = 1$.

$w = z + a$ — Translation

Each point is shifted by the vector a . Circles map to circles of the same radius; lines map to parallel lines.

$$w = \frac{1}{z} \text{ — Inversion}$$

This maps circles and lines to circles and lines (in general). Key fact: $\frac{1}{z} = \frac{\bar{z}}{|z|^2}$, so points on $|z| = 1$ map to themselves.

Example: Find the image of $|z| = 2$ under $w = \frac{1}{z}$.

Set $w = \frac{1}{z}$, so $z = \frac{1}{w}$. The condition $|z| = 2$ becomes $\left|\frac{1}{w}\right| = 2$, i.e. $|w| = \frac{1}{2}$. The image is the circle $|w| = \frac{1}{2}$.

Example: Find the image of the line $\operatorname{Re}(z) = 1$ under $w = \frac{1}{z}$.

Let $z = x + iy$ with $x = 1$. Then $w = \frac{1}{1+iy} = \frac{1-iy}{1+y^2}$, so $u = \frac{1}{1+y^2}$, $v = \frac{-y}{1+y^2}$.

Note $u^2 + v^2 = \frac{1}{(1+y^2)^2}(1+y^2) = \frac{1}{1+y^2} = u$. So $u^2 + v^2 = u$, i.e. $\left(u - \frac{1}{2}\right)^2 + v^2 = \frac{1}{4}$ — a circle.

AQA Exam Technique

Common mistakes:

- **Argument range:** AQA usually requires $-\pi < \arg z \leq \pi$. Always check the quadrant before computing.
- **Square roots:** $(a + bi)^2 = (a^2 - b^2) + 2abi$: set up two simultaneous equations.
- **Real coefficients:** If a polynomial has real coefficients, complex roots come in conjugate pairs — use this immediately.
- **Loci:** Always check whether boundary points are included (open vs closed circle on Argand diagram).
- **De Moivre:** When asked for $\sin^n \theta$ or $\cos^n \theta$ in multiple angles, use $z \pm z^{-1}$ and expand the binomial.

Mark scheme patterns:

- Modulus-argument form: $[M1]$ for finding both r and θ (two B marks if straightforward).
- For transformation questions: show your substitution clearly ($z = \frac{1}{w}$ or similar) then algebraically simplify.
- For locus proofs: state the equation, then confirm it represents the named curve.
- If asked to *sketch* a locus, mark key points (centre, radius, or endpoints) for method marks.

Topic	Key formula	Common error
Modulus	$ a + bi = \sqrt{a^2 + b^2}$	Forgetting to square root
Argument	$\arg z = \arctan(b/a)$ adjusted for quadrant	Using $\arctan$ without checking quadrant
De Moivre	$(re^{i\theta})^n = r^n e^{in\theta}$	Forgetting to raise r to the power n
n th roots	Divide argument by n , add $2\pi k/n$	Finding only one root, not all n
Circle locus	$ z - a = r$: centre a , radius r	Wrong centre (sign error in a)
Half-line locus	$\arg(z - a) = \theta$: starts at a (not included), at angle θ	Including the starting point a ; wrong direction
Perpendicular bisector	$ z - a = z - b $: locus midway between a and b	Not finding midpoint; confusing with circle
Conjugate roots	For real coefficients, complex roots come in conjugate pairs	Forgetting to include conjugate in factorisation

Remember: in AQA, the principal argument is $-\pi < \arg z \leq \pi$. Angles outside this range must be adjusted. For loci sketches, clearly mark any excluded points (open circles) and indicate the direction of half-lines with an arrow.

Quick reminder — Euler's formula: $e^{i\theta} = \cos \theta + i \sin \theta$, so $e^{i\pi} + 1 = 0$ (Euler's identity).
Useful: $\cos \theta = \operatorname{Re}(e^{i\theta})$ and $\sin \theta = \operatorname{Im}(e^{i\theta})$. Summing geometric series with ratio $e^{i\theta}$ gives sums of $\cos n\theta$ and $\sin n\theta$.